

01

RELIGION WITHOUT GOD

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Fact: Recent 2025–2026 scholarship and reviews continue to discuss religious naturalism as an attempt to retain awe, value, ritual and community within a naturalistic worldview. □□ Inference: This strengthens the conceptual question whether supernatural belief is necessary for religion, but it does not displace the syllabus's primary evidence: Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā and Sāṃkhya.

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02

RELIGION WITHOUT GOD: CORE DISTINCTIONS

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Feuerbach, Marx, Freud and Nietzsche challenge theistic religion respectively as projection, ideology, wish-fulfilment and a life-denying value-framework, but criticism of theism does not by itself construct a religion without God.

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Ninian Smart's dimensions: religion has doctrinal, mythic, ethical, ritual, experiential, social & material dimensions — belief in a creator God is not on the essential list. □ A functional definition: religion = a way of life orienting one toward ultimate meaning, liberation, and the transcendent/absolute — which need not be a personal God. □□ Hence "religion without God" is coherent: the sacred/ultimate ≠ necessarily a deity.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Master verdict: A personal creator is not necessary for religion, but some disciplined orientation to ultimacy, transformation, community and soteriology is needed to prevent the category from becoming empty.

ANSWER LINE: Religion is a disciplined orientation to an ultimate or sacred order through doctrine, practice, community and transformation; belief in a personal creator is not a necessary

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ANSWER LINE: Religion is a disciplined orientation to an ultimate or sacred order through doctrine, practice, community and transformation; belief in a personal creator is not a necessary condition.